

Music 246 – Lecture 4

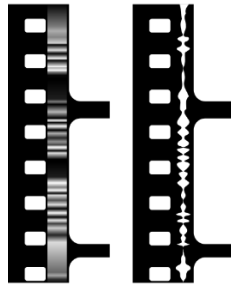
See Last Week for the end of Week 3

Part A – Transition to Sound

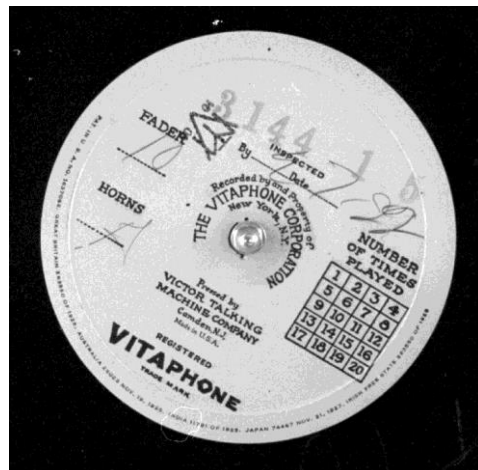
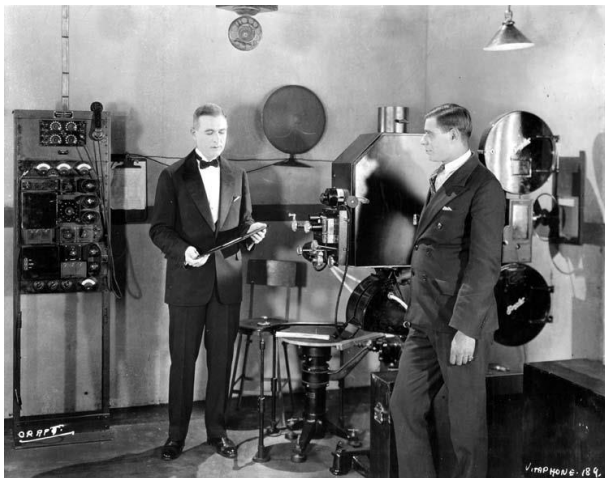
Solution to the problems of musical accompaniment – recorded and synchronized sound.

Transition to Sound:

- sound and silent films existed together for several years.
 - Economic issues
 - “talkies” were initially seen as a fad
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- demonstrations of sound films as early as 1922
 - several competing systems emerge - the two primary approaches are:
 1. Sound On Film: (Phonofilm, Movietone) Photograph of sound waves on the edge of the film – excellent synchronization, poor audio quality.



2. Sound On Disk: (Warner Brothers' Vitaphone) Audio recording on a phonograph disk, synchronized with the film projector – excellent audio quality, poor synchronization.



- 1926 Don Juan



- Recorded score primarily by William Axt, performed by the New York Philharmonic Orchestra.
- Vitaphone – recorded music and some sound effects. No dialog, still a silent film.
- Also had a second score created for “live” performance – Why?

The Jazz Singer (1927)



VIDEO EXAMPLE: The Jazz Singer (1927) – Blue Skies

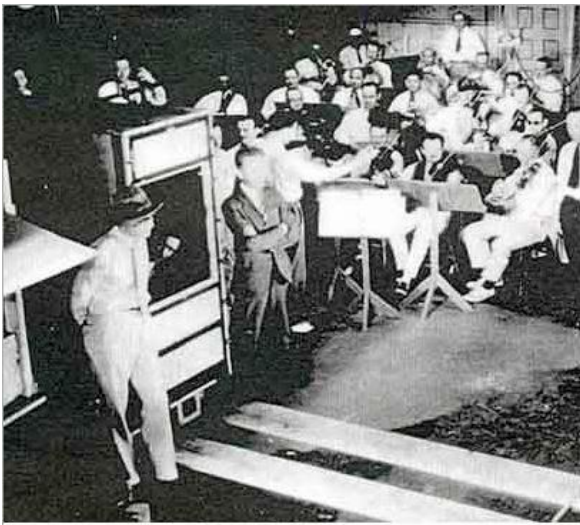
- primarily silent, with several minutes of synchronized sound.
- most of the score is compiled or adapted.
- made use of the Vitaphone System.
- Why is it still primarily a silent film?
- a financial hit
- signaled the “beginning of the end” of the silent era.

- Sound on Disk has the early lead, but Sound on Film will become the standard by the early 1930s.

Changes Connected to Sound

1. Aesthetics:

- Film had developed visually as a silent medium.
- Acting style / voices
- Many worried about using none-diegetic music: “Where does the music come from?”



George Groves stands (arms folded) next to a camera booth on the set of *The Singing Fool*. The booth was a solid wall box with double plate glass windows which the cameraman shot through.

2. Making films:

- all sound had to be recorded in real time.
- musicians on set – balance of sound music and dialog.
- cameras in large booths – no movement.
- “sound stages” are built to reduce outside noises

3. Showing Films:

- Too many contesting sound systems.
- Small number of the 20,000 theaters equipped for sound.
- end of 1929 almost 1000 theatres equipped for sound.
- by 1935 the transition is complete.

Fun Examples: “Singin’ In The Rain” (1952)

Singin In The Rain 1 – Issues with filming

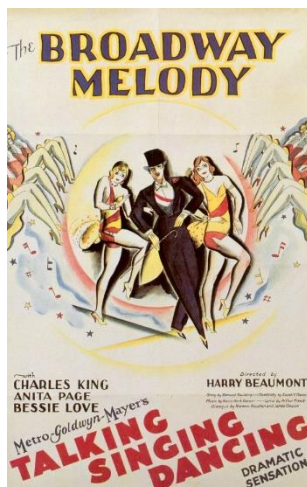
Singin In The Rain 2 – Issues with exhibition

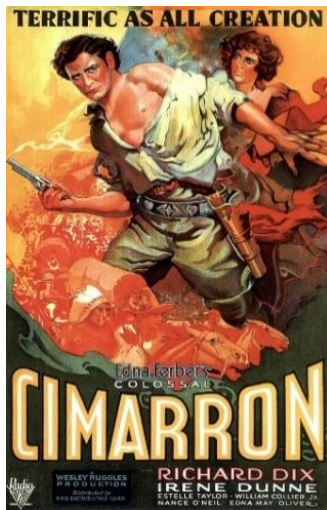


Max Steiner: (1888-1971)



- born in Vienna, middle class, father owned a theatre
- formally trained in the tradition of European classical music.
- child prodigy – conducting in theatre by 12 – touring as a conductor by 16
- wrote operettas, first by age 17
- also worked as composer and conductor of music for stage in England.
- facing deportation because of WWI Comes to US in 1914
 - worked on Broadway for 15 years.
 - Invited to Hollywood in 1929, **Rio Rita**
 - problems with actors' voices - Hollywood turns to Broadway.
 - 1929 production of musicals and theatrical reviews.
 - **Rio Rita / Broadway Melody**





- By 1930, little music in dramatic films – “where does it come from?”
- **Cimarron** (1931) Score by Max Steiner
- David Selznick, at RKO recognized that more music might be effective, despite the risk of confusing the audience.



- (1932) **Symphony of 6 Million**, and **Bird of Paradise**.

The End